Reciprocal Partnership Models:

Equality and Effectiveness in International Education Partnerships

A Wales-Africa partnership research report
for Dolen Cymru Lesotho

by Elaine Christian

This document is an extract from the full report on Dolen Cymru Lesotho partnerships, which focuses only on partnerships in education. The full report is available here.

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About Dolen Cymru Lesotho

Dolen LESOTHO CYMRU

Dolen connects two small countries at opposite ends of our world – Wales and Lesotho. They bring people together from both countries who want to make lasting positive change in their communities. Whether it is with health workers, teachers, communities: They bring knowledge, learning and ideas together which is shared and spread across communities in Lesotho and in Wales.

dolencymru.org

About the author

Dr Elaine Christian is a social anthropologist, qualitative researcher, and partnership facilitator. Her work promotes hopeful acts of friendship and build bridges of understanding. She is an expert in international partnerships between humanitarian organisations, providing end-to-end social research and evaluation programmes to support strong, equitable, and sustainable relationships.

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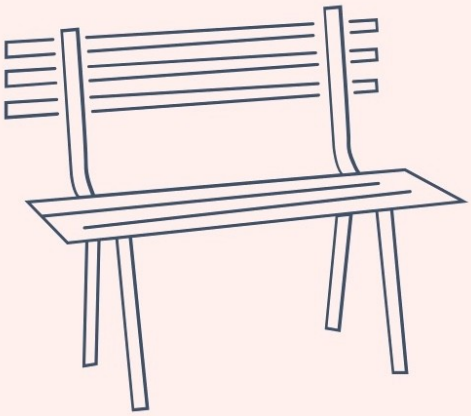

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1. Executive Summary

Note: This executive summary covers the full research report, of which this document is an extract. Click here for the full report.

Kakaretso ena e fumaneha ka Sesotho.

Mae'r crynodeb hwn ar gael yn Gymraeg.

1.1. Context

Dolen Cymru Lesotho is a network of links between Wales and Lesotho, with partner organisations including schools, health boards, sports clubs, community advocacy organisations, and faith groups. Partnerships between Wales and Lesotho are encouraged and supported to build long-term relationships based on friendships, using a balanced and reciprocal model of partnership. In addition, Dolen has signed up to Hub Cymru Africa's Anti-Racism Charter and is working towards those goals.

In 2024, Dolen commissioned a research project to investigate the role of their partnership model in building more equal and effective partnership working. This research addressed the following questions:

1. Does the "Dolen model" contribute to effective and equal partnership working, compared to other models? If so, how? and can these contributing factors be built on further?
2. What implications from (1) are there for Dolen, volunteers, and partners (e.g. in terms of organisational structure, approaches to partnership working, or link activities)?
3. What potential implications from (1) are there for the wider Wales Africa community?
4. For both Dolen and the wider Wales Africa community: through the lens of Solidarity and the intentions of the Wales Africa Anti-Racism Charter, what lessons can be learned from investigating the effectiveness of partnership working, both Dolen's model and other similar models identified in literature? What can be avoided, replicated, or adapted in order to contribute to increased Global Solidarity and the role of Wales as an outward looking nation?

1.2. Research and Findings

Research was conducted by Dr Elaine Christian, with link participants from the education, health, sport, and faith sectors; including volunteers, partner organisation staff, funders, and Dolen board members and staff.

Four characteristics emerged which were shared between partnerships with higher degrees of balance and equal involvement, or with a greater self-reported sense of equality and effectiveness. These are:

1. Reciprocity and bilaterality: A sense of balance in travel, programming and roles. Roughly equal numbers of visitors travel in each direction, similar activities are occurring in each place, and there is a shared sense between partners that they have a similar contribution to the relationship.
2. Organisational embeddedness: The relationship becomes part of the organisation's identity, with executive levels supporting the partnership and policies in place to support participation.

3. Friendship and commitment: Recognition that the relationship itself is of value, worthy of investment of both time and finances.
4. Regular evaluation: Partners make a priority of examining and evaluating the health of the relationship—including efforts towards equality—at regular intervals.

Research shows clearly that these characteristics are tightly interlinked and support each other; I refer to them as the "Four Strands" throughout the report as a way to understand and interpret research findings. Strengthening one strand positively affects the others, and conversely, if one is lacking, then adverse affects are seen in the others.

Overall, research indicates that:

- The "Dolen model" does contribute to equal and effective partnership working. Partnerships with greater reciprocity are more likely to characterise their relationships as equal and effective.
- Greater reciprocity and bilaterality were also associated with personal and professional development, cultural learning, overcoming challenges, and increasing awareness.
- The "Dolen model" can be applied inconsistently: some organisations may have greater equality in travel but less so in programming or partner roles, or vice versa.
- A few partnerships resemble more strongly the "donor-recipient" model, although these organisations tend to take a more collaborative and partner-led approach. Partners in Lesotho consistently report that they appreciate working with Dolen-affiliated organisations for this reason.
- Welsh partners have, in a few cases, been able to contribute to greater equality and effectiveness by challenging assumptions or practices of funders, e.g. around reporting requirements.

1.3. Implications & Recommendations

- Partner organisations require continued support in strengthening each of the "four strands" identified. This could include developing guides for best practice, hands-on resources, training, etc.
- Relationships between thematically-linked partners (i.e. organisations with a similar social remit) can be highly effective, and a way to increase participation in global solidarity. New partners can be identified, and existing partners encouraged to develop their work in this area.
- Partner organisations can be encouraged and supported with practical ways to influence the funding landscape to re-orient itself towards longer-term and friendship-based approaches.

2. Introduction

For the past 40 years, Dolen Cymru Lesotho has been bringing together people from Wales and Lesotho in order to make positive changes in their communities. From the beginning, Dolen has approached international partnerships from a viewpoint that friendship and understanding would build involvement, and involvement would build collaboration between individuals, communities, and organisations, leading to common action in a particular sphere.

Dolen has been moving towards a balanced and reciprocal model of partnership based on equal involvement: all link partners join together in friendship based on common work in promoting civic action and solidarity. Each partner is as involved in promoting equality and advancing progress in health, education, etc. in their own locality as in their partner's. Dolen understands this model to be in contrast to the partnership models frequently found in other international NGOs, particularly the "funding-implementing" partnership model, where one partner funds and directs projects that are implemented exclusively by the other partner, without any parallel action taking place in the funder's location. and in 2024, Dolen commissioned a research project to investigate whether this model contributes to more effective and equal partnership working.

In addition, Dolen Cymru Lesotho has signed up to Hub Cymru Africa's Anti-Racism Charter. In particular, they have committed to working on Charter Points 3, 4, 8, 9, and 11. This research specifically addresses Charter Points 3 and 4, and—although it is not yet an area of focus—Charter Point 5 significantly informed how the research was conducted.

> 3. We will work in a manner which recognises and prioritises in-country expertise and knowledge to lead our work and support this with an equitable pay structure.
>
> 4. We will commit to taking ownership of developing our own deeper understanding of the issues of racism and how they impact our thinking.
>
> 5. We are an organisation that welcomes critical feedback, with a view to learning and improving our work. We will act without defensiveness or negative repercussions for those highlighting racist or colonial practices and create accountability mechanisms within our work.

This report will summarise the findings of that research, and develop some lessons going forward. In Section 3 I outline the methodological approach to research, and in Section 4 I discuss common themes between partnerships. In section 5 I analyse how these common themes appear in education partnerships, and in Section 6 I identify some implications for the wider Wales Africa community before concluding in section 8.

2.1. Notes on report style

In this report, I have departed from a tendency in many research settings of writing in a detached third-person style. My purpose in doing so is to acknowledge that my research, like any other research, is a product of a specific person's history, education, and view of how knowledge and understanding are built; and not an objectively neutral (and therefore supposedly authoritative) account of bare facts.

3. Methodology

This research project draws on the history of Dolen's education links, and aims to improve their understanding of the efficacy of their partnership work, and specifically the friendship-based model of partnership in use.

3.1. Purpose of project

The purpose of the Wales-Africa Partnership Research project is to improve Dolen Cymru Lesotho's understanding of the efficacy of their partnership work, and specifically of the "balanced involvement" model of partnership in use.

Objectives:

1. Understand the ways in which Dolen's partnership model affects the work being done by link members
2. Identify strengths and build on these further
3. Identify weaknesses or areas for improvement, and make necessary changes
4. Contribute to a broader understanding within the larger Wales-Africa community of the role of partnership work in promoting global solidarity

3.2. Overview of research design & methodology

The principal questions guiding this investigation, developed in collaboration with the Dolen co-directors, were:

5. Does the "Dolen model" contribute to effective and equal partnership working, compared to other models? If so, how? and can these contributing factors be built on further?
6. What implications from (1) are there for Dolen, volunteers, and partners (e.g. in terms of organisational structure, approaches to partnership working, or link activities)?
7. What potential implications from (1) are there for the wider Wales Africa community?
8. For both Dolen and the wider Wales Africa community: through the lens of Solidarity and the intentions of the Wales Africa Anti-Racism Charter, what lessons can be learned from investigating the effectiveness of partnership working, both Dolen's model and other similar models identified in literature? What can be avoided, replicated, or adapted in order to contribute to increased Global Solidarity and the role of Wales as an outward looking nation?

At the outset of the project, I met with several stakeholders and members of the Wales-Africa community to develop a shared understanding of the research project and the key concepts to be investigated, and to identify what a successful project would look like.

Stakeholders discussed the key concepts of "effectiveness" and "equality": what they look like in practice, and how they would be recognised in a partnership. In addition, stakeholders identified key individuals or roles that should be asked to participate, as well as potential audiences for eventual findings.

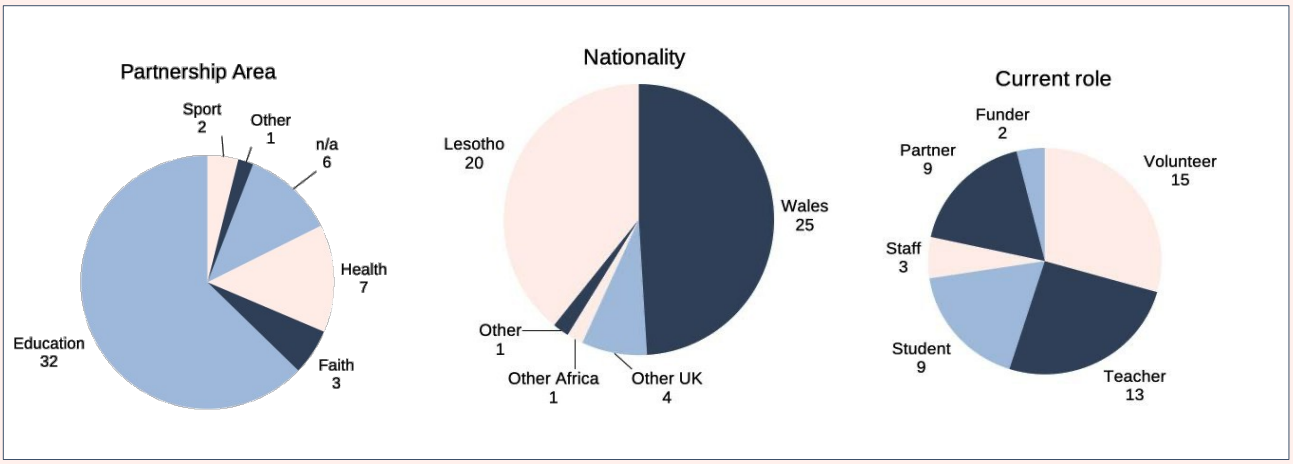
3.3. Data collection

Research was carried out between June and August of 2024, using qualitative methods. In June and July I observed several activities coordinated around a visit from Lesotho to Wales. These included a board meeting and strategy session; a workshop for Basotho teachers on a placement in Wales; a school day at Glan-y-Môr Secondary School where several exchange students from Moyeni High School, along with

two teachers, were visiting; and a *mokete* celebration for all visitors to Wales. Glan-y-Môr and Moyeni in particular have a longstanding and well known link; participants from both schools often refer to it as Glan-y-Moyeni.

In addition, I conducted qualitative interviews with Dolen staff, funders, board members, partners, volunteers, and exchange participants; and focus groups with board members, exchange participants, and teachers on placement.

Participant demographics are shown below:



Although this document is an extract discussing only education partnerships, the figures above represent demographics from the research project as a whole. One priority was to not focus on any one area to the exclusion of others, recognising that health and education have historically been the two main partnership areas while acknowledging that other areas (including faith and sport) have had less activity. While it does seem as though there were many more participants from education partnerships, it should be pointed out that my research in education settings (including with exchange students and teachers) included several group interviews and focus groups. For example, I conducted an interview with about 13 students who were involved in exchange visits; on another occasion I organised a focus group for five teachers and two volunteers assisting with the Wales Teacher Placement Programme. Overall, the total level of participation was about equal for health and education partnerships.

3.4. Analysis

I chose a comparative analytical approach, specifically comparing degrees of reciprocity and balance, and identifying commonalities and differences between partnerships. I used Dedoose for data analysis, with a combined inductive and deductive coding approach. All interviews were transcribed for analysis, along with observational notes and outputs (flipcharts, worksheets, etc.) from focus groups and workshops.

4. Commonalities

The comparative approach I worked with starts with the acknowledgement that a definitive answer to Research Question 1 would be difficult to provide, since it would require:

- An extensive comparative research programme, including other well-defined partnership models
- Consensus on the meanings of “effective”, “equal”, or indeed “partnership”

- Consistent application of the "Dolen model" across different partnership areas

It soon became apparent that while there are definite trends and tendencies, the research programme would not be able to rely upon these factors. Therefore, I looked at similarities between partnerships within Dolen. I took the concepts of balance, reciprocity, and equal involvement as key indicators, and sought to identify whether partnerships that seemed to implement these to a greater extent had anything in common; and conversely, whether partnerships that had a lower degree of balanced, reciprocal, or equal involvement had any commonalities. Four common characteristics emerged, all of which interlink with and support the others. Therefore I will use an image of woven strands to illustrate these common characteristics, and I'll refer to them as the "Four Strands" (Figure 1).

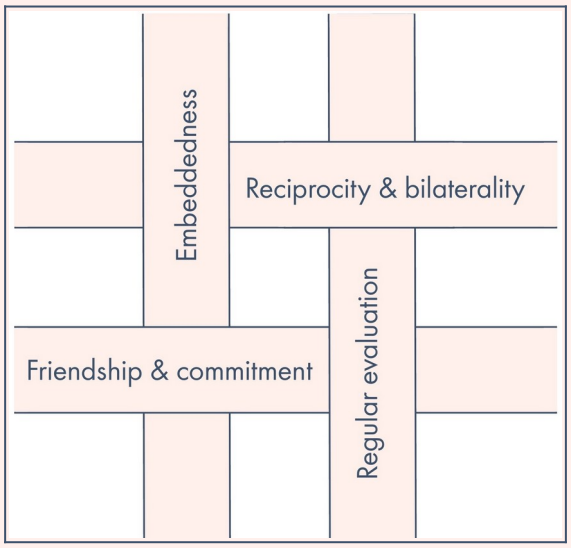


Figure 1: The Four Strands

4.1. Reciprocity & Bilaterality

This refers to a sense of balance: in travel, in programming, and in the roles that partners take on. That is, participants from Lesotho and Wales visit each other in more or less equal numbers, similar programming is happening in both locations, and partners in both locations make similar contributions to the partnership.

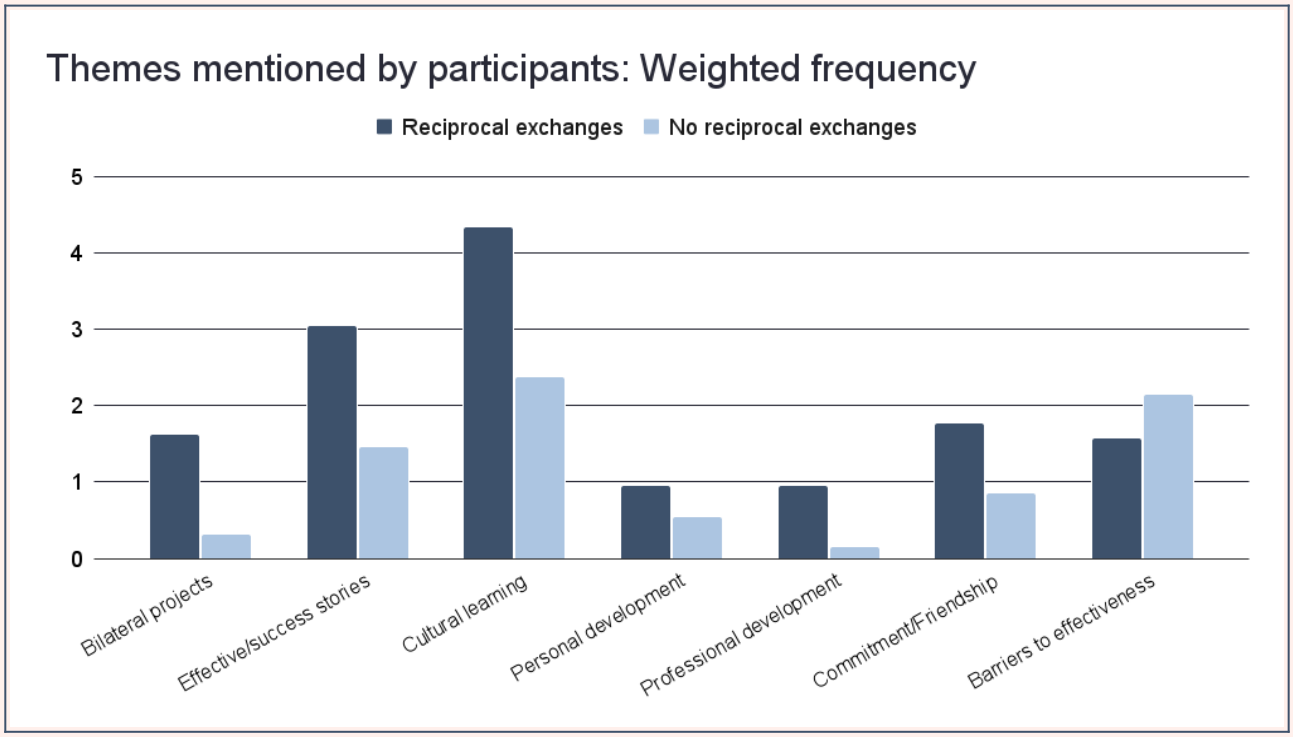


Figure 2: Themes mentioned by participants

The chart in Figure 2 illustrates how partners with higher levels of reciprocity and bilaterality mentioned positive themes more often in interviews than those with lower levels.

In addition, participants with higher levels of reciprocity and bilaterality directly and explicitly connected numerous benefits to the reciprocity of the relationship (Figure 3).

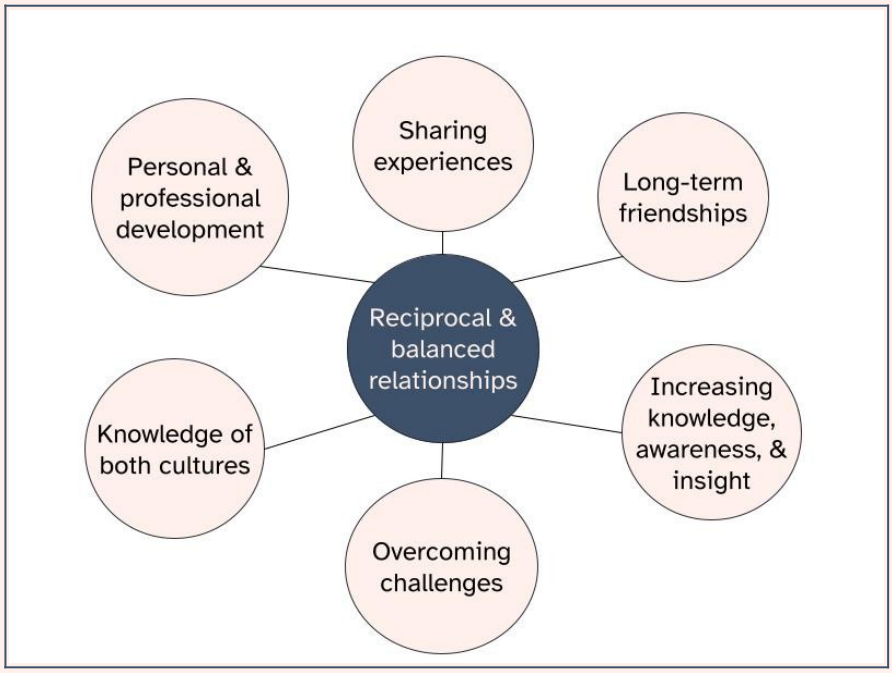


Figure 3: Benefits connected to reciprocal relationships

In contrast, partners with lower levels of reciprocity and bilaterality were more likely to mention challenges to effectiveness:

> "I don't do exchanges as such. What I do is fundraising. ... It's hard to get [others] involved, though. I try and try, but no one has bought into it to the same degree [as my organisation]." *(Participant in a sport partnership from Wales)*

> "We do get quite frustrated. It seems that everything we try just doesn't yield the results we would like. It's hard to know what to do to change that. *(Participant in a health partnership from Wales)*

4.2. Organisational embeddedness

There are two aspects of embedding a partnership within an organisation that I observed. One is in terms of the organisation's identity, where the partnership becomes part of what members or participants perceive that organisation to be (an excellent example is school twinning relationships). The other is having buy-in from the executive level, meaning that senior officers at the organisation are aware of the partnership and support it, and that official policies are in place to support participation. The result is that the organisation as a whole bears the responsibility to the partnership, rather than individual participants.

One specific contribution that Dolen has made is in providing a structure to support greater embeddedness. A Dolen board member, mentioning a previous partnership he had participated, said:

> "That other partnership's died. I think it depended on the people. But, with Dolen, because of the structure, it helps it sustain itself. I've seen people come and go over the last 30 years."

4.3. Friendship & Commitment

Developing a sense of friendship or committed long-term relationship was linked by participants to greater effectiveness and equal working. By "friendship" and "commitment", I mean a sense that the relationship itself is of value, worthy of attention and investment of time or resources, rather than looking more towards any specific projects or outcomes that come out of the relationship.

Long-term friendships were linked to ...		... leading to these outcomes
Developing stronger sense of trust	➔	More equitable distribution of risk
Seeing each other as partners, with mutual respect	➔	Increased sense of equality between partners
Taking a long-term and holistic view of initiatives	➔	Identifying more effective and impactful initiatives
Ability to discuss and understand needs more freely	➔	Increased equality and programme effectiveness

Participants consistently spoke of long-term involvement and commitment as a unique benefit of their partnerships through Dolen:

> "One thing I picked up quite early at working in Lesotho was people saying, oh yes, you've been around for some time. And it's the impression that many other agencies, people will come and work on the project, and then disappear. Whereas this is something that's actually lasted for 40 years. *(Dolen board member from Wales)*

4.4. Regular evaluation

Finally, partners with higher levels of balance, reciprocity, and equality make a priority of examining and evaluating the health of the relationship—including efforts towards equality—at regular intervals. Many organisations do regular monitoring and evaluation exercises, but here I specifically refer to evaluating the relationship itself and not only its programming or initiatives. This may include external research or evaluation, but more often it is a regular part of the organisation's work where participants request and value partner's feedback, consciously question assumptions, dialogue with partners, and address power imbalances.

In the next section, I will discuss how these strands appear within education partnerships, and highlight some outcomes identified by participants.

5. Education

Research indicates that the partnerships in education are by far the most reciprocal of all the types of partnership that come under the Dolen umbrella. Education partnerships enjoy a very high degree of

reciprocity, as each school link that I encountered in my research had participated in both visiting and hosting. In addition, there is a high degree of bilaterality: Participating organisations are all schools, with the same basic objective (educating young people); and bilateral projects are common where each school carries out a similar project:

> "We looked at sustainability. We built a keyhole garden in Lesotho, which was out of plastic bottles and planted there. They'd also done a greenhouse out of plastic bottles as well, which was very cool. And then the idea was that when they came to Wales, we would build a keyhole garden in our country as well, which we did in the Burns Centre in Kidwelly. So that was introducing the idea. They planted vegetables that were suited for their country to be able to grow. We've had photos sent to us as well, so it's really nice to see that they're keeping it going. And we've got the same." *(student exchange participant from Wales)*

Participants in school exchanges connected the reciprocal nature of the partnership with benefits in several areas which highlight the Four Strands:

5.1. Developing friendships and relationships

Participants (both teachers and students) spoke about how the mutual nature of the partnership brought people together and contributed to the development of cross-cultural friendships. Several exchange participants have been in touch with people that they met on exchange, even after several years; in one case, a Welsh participant was invited to a celebration of a significant event in the life of a Basotho participant. Those who participated in a homestay felt they were able to develop an even stronger sense of trust with their guest or host. This contributed to an atmosphere of equality: students identified other exchange participants as peers, and teachers regularly referred to other teaching exchange participants colleagues, thereby developing a sense of mutual appreciation and respect.

Participants also spoke about developing deeper relationships with people from their own country. One participant in the teacher exchange programme spoke about how she and the other four teachers (who had not all known each other previously) had developed a special bond between them as a result of their shared experience. These teachers felt that upon their return to Lesotho, they would have another network of support developed through this experience.

5.2. Embedding the relationship within the school's organisational identity

Having a more longstanding link that has become part of the school's identity was mentioned by some participants as an important outcome of reciprocal partnership. This, in turn, was linked several further benefits.

1. Travel between Lesotho and Wales can be daunting for a student, but having a known entity as the destination, and one that students' predecessors have visited, makes the experience smoother.
2. Students, even those who have not travelled themselves, have a wider scope of reference in terms of cross-cultural understanding. Student participants report that a majority of students in the school are interested or engaged in the link at least to some extent. In addition, there is the freedom to

devote school time and resources to partnership activities for all students and not just exchange participants – for example, the "Cultural Day" that students had put on during the visit from Lesotho:

> "There's staff involvement and school ethos – we are supported, we have always been supported by management to have a day like this happening." *(Teacher at a school in Wales)*

3. Staff and students have a deeper level of commitment, and greater involvement in the partnership, with further develops a sense of trust: in a conversation with several Dolen ambassadors (college students who had participated in exchange trips as secondary students, at different schools), I asked roughly what proportion of the student body would be highly engaged in the partnership, how many generally interested but not engaged, and how many not interested. The ambassadors agreed that more students at Glan-y-Môr school were more highly engaged than at Bryngwyn, specifically because Glan-y-Môr had enjoyed a longer link whereas Bryngwyn's was much newer.
4. The partnership is more durable, and is not affected by staff turnover.

5.3. Effectiveness in working together

Participants connected having a reciprocal and mutual relationship which is part of the school's identity, to a greater sense of effectiveness in personal and educational outcomes. For example, Welsh staff compared their link with Lesotho to other exchange programmes they have participated in. With the Lesotho link, they said, students become more engaged, taking it upon themselves to suggest particular initiatives (such as putting on a school-wide "Cultural Day") or work together on specific projects (including improvements to the school grounds), rather than the exchange being something of a glorified holiday.

Teaching exchange participants from Lesotho also spoke about how their experience could increase effectiveness within the partnership by bringing a broader perspective to other educators, and widen participation:

> "In the long run, it's we Basotho people that are now understanding – we could rethink, introspect ourselves. We know the benefits that we have got here, and we need to ensure that we bring light into other schools. Other schools have to benefit this – this is not for our sake, it is for the sake of a Mosotho child that we are working with. So it is through that mentality that we can now demonstrate the broadening, or the expansion, of this project. And even [meeting] the teachers, the certain principals, orientate them about this, show them what we have acquired, so that they voluntarily get into partnership." *(Teaching exchange participant from Lesotho)*

5.4. Promoting cultural learning & heritage

Participants connect the mutual partnership to experiences of improving their cross-cultural understanding, which connects strongly to both effectiveness and equality. Exchange participants spoke about learning more about their partner country and developing an interest in further study of global issues:

> "It's definitely made me aware of the fact that I am very interested in what goes on in other countries. And just the cultures and history of the countries. Before going to Lesotho ... it was very much, if I'm abroad, I'm relaxing. But going there, it completely changed my mindset of how I approach going abroad. I was like, I want to know more, and I want to know why they do things the way they do, and how that affects their life, and how is that different from us? It really opened my mind to those type of questions." *(Student exchange participant from Wales)*

In particular, both teachers and students report that they felt the learning they experienced was more profound, or felt more "real" to them, due to the personal and first-hand nature of their experience whether travelling themselves or hosting visitors through the exchange programme:

> "Prior to my experience with Lesotho I didn't realize quite how transformational these kind of experiences could be but I think part of that is – it's a project, not a trip. It's very much about, they prepare, they work in their dinner times, they work after school, to prepare for their visit out, and prepare for receiving the visit. They put a lot into it. And as a result, I think they get far more out of it. And I think that's a really good life lesson at the base here." *(Headteacher of school in Wales)*

One teacher in Wales, who was hosting visitors from Lesotho, reported that more than one of his students who had had xenophobic tendencies in the past were able to open up to the visitors and interact positively with them. The visiting teacher who was with them concurred:

> "I've seen that those students who have never met other cultures – it was a great huge impact that I have, we have, experienced. Because you find that some of the students were cold to foreigners. But interacting with them, showing love, has made a better environment. Also that, as the learners, they can express their culture here, the Wales culture. How's living here. And to me it has been so excellent." *(Teaching exchange participant from Lesotho)*

Several participants in Welsh schools spoke of the exchange helping them feel in touch more with their Welsh identity:

> "Because of this trip [to Lesotho] I did research a bit more into Wales and then me and my nan went to visit St Fagans, which is the National Museum of Wales. And then that prepared me a bit for [a subsequent exchange in] Korea, so I could speak about what being Welsh is and how it's different to being British and English." *(Student exchange participant from Wales)*

While staff in particular connected the exchanges to a process of discovering their own identity and cultural heritage by having a broader sense of the world in which to place themselves:

> "For you to really appreciate or identify your cultural heritage, you need to have that sense of self and that sense of your place in the world, and I think this is where the program is really important, because you have teenage students coming together that, in so many ways—and this is what always surprising—have so much in common, yet their two different cultures give them very different takes. And I think that challenges the

students in terms of where their own sense of place is and then helps them find it." *(Headteacher from a school in Wales)*

In addition, teaching staff felt that a sizeable minority of Welsh student participants (one estimated it at 15-20 percent) were developing an understanding of deeper issues at a global political level which went beyond a surface understanding – that is, moving beyond a generalised sense of learning about cultural differences and feeling a greater sense of gratitude, to asking challenging questions about the drivers of global inequality. A teaching exchange participant from Lesotho felt that this could be built upon through increased collaboration throughout the year, more frequent communication and engagement, learning about politics, and discussing news and current events in each country.

5.5. Personal and professional development

Exchange participants connected the reciprocal nature of the programme to both personal and professional development. Teachers particularly mentioned development in both areas, with those on placement programmes emphasising professional development.

> "A hundred percent. I'm going to say that for you. One hundred percent. Absolutely. A hundred percent." *(Teacher at a school in Wales, asked whether the partnership has influenced her professional development)*

> "We get to be exposed to different cultures and whatever we get from the schools—how the teachers teach, the strategies, the technology—it's some of the things that we take back home that's going to improve our educational outcomes. *(Teaching exchange participant from Lesotho)*

> "I'm not bored of my job, okay. However, having those international projects going on, bringing people together ... brings a massive dimension to my job. I don't know whether I would have gone and done something else if I didn't have those, but I know for a fact that it is a motivating aspect of my – well, of myself as an educator." *(Teacher at a school in Wales)*

> "At our schools in Lesotho, we [also] have got different learners with special needs, and those who undergo through drug abuse, and different challenges at home. Looking at how they approach, and talking with them about how they approach the learners and bring change: that has made me, as a teacher, when I go back, I share with my fellow teachers, it's good. Okay, this kind of tool helps students to bring change, a positive change in their lives. We approach them with love, compassion. We don't shout at them." *(Teaching exchange participant from Lesotho, on his experience at a Pupil Referral Unit school in Wales)*

Two participants (one from Lesotho and one from Wales) specifically attributed career progression to their experience of partnerships in education.

Teachers also pointed out personal development that students experienced. As for the students, they often mentioned aspects of personal development:

> "When they go back, they're going to tell the stories about knowing Wales and how it has related positively to their lives. And they're saying also that the primary students already want to go to Moyeni High School to have the partnership or the relationship with Wales. And at their school, they are selected based on their performance. So that is improving their grades because everyone wants to work hard to be able to come to Wales. So they think it's making a very big impact in Lesotho." *(Student exchange participants from Lesotho; translated by teacher)*

In addition, older students spoke of how they were inspired by the exchange programme to pursue education leading to specific career options.

5.6. Summary

Of the participants in education partnerships that I spoke to, all of them without exception were satisfied with the programmes. While many were able to identify areas for improvement, or point out places where they felt the programme could be better, every participant felt generally positive, encouraged, and motivated by the partnerships. Several interview participants specifically directed me to make sure I recorded in my notes how pleased they were with the programme, how strongly they believed in it, and how much they wanted it to continue and expand. Perhaps the best illustration was in my interview with the headteacher at a secondary school. When I asked if I could speak to him, he said, "Sure, though I have another meeting I need to be in at 4." Our interview went on for a little while, and when I noticed it was gone 4 o'clock, I asked if he needed to wrap up. He looked up at the clock, surprised, and said, "Whoops! No, this is important. If nothing else, that's the most important thing."

One pitfall that must be considered is the occasional tendency to see the basic lesson to be learned from an exchange as, "See how much better it is in Wales." While this was never the explicit message, Welsh students often mentioned their main takeaway as realising how fortunate they are, while Basotho teachers often discussed their classrooms in Lesotho in terms of deficiencies (whether in terms of technology, teaching practice, curriculum, or others). This is a difficult message to counter, as it connects to a near universal tendency to value material wealth and technological achievement.

6. Implications for Wider Wales-Africa Community

Research Question 1 asks whether the "Dolen model" contributes to equal and effective partnership working, and if so, how. Research Questions 3 and 4 ask what potential implications this may have for the wider Wales-Africa community; and what lessons can be learned from investigating the effectiveness of partnership working – especially through the lens of solidarity and the Wales Africa Anti-Racism charter.

6.1. Presentation at Global Solidarity Summit

To address this question, I and one of Dolen's co-directors presented an interactive session at the Hub Cymru Africa's Global Solidarity Summit in September 2024. The session included a summary of the full research findings (organised around the Four Strands mentioned above: Reciprocal exchanges, organisational embeddedness, long-term commitment, and regular evaluation of the relationship). Participants then had an opportunity to work together in groups with a graphical handout showing some

of the research outcomes visually, to comment on it and add their own thoughts. At the end of the session, in a "head-heart-hand" exercise, participants were invited to contribute something they had learned, something they felt, and something they could do.

Overall, the initial conclusions presented seemed to track with participants' experiences. Groups were generally in agreement that there is ample evidence that reciprocity is highly effective and offers numerous benefits, but occasionally commented that despite its importance, it is difficult to achieve and some organisations do not have the capacity to deliver parallel projects. Similarly, participants agreed that embedding relationships at organisational level is important, but that ongoing recruitment of volunteers can be a challenge.

Participants offering contributions at the end of the exercise frequently mentioned the importance of evaluation or "partnership health checks" as something they had learned, along with the benefits of greater reciprocity and of building trust and commitment. Most participants felt positive about the research presented: Happy that the subject was being talked about more frequently, motivated to improve their practice, or more confident in their ability to build relationships. Others did mention feeling overwhelmed or vulnerable, but reassured that they had a useful forum in which to discuss partnership challenges.

Finally, participants suggested concrete actions that could come out of the presentation. Several mentioned investigating more balanced or reciprocal approaches (e.g. investigating possibilities for school-to-school partnerships, or mutual education), while others mentioned implementing regular evaluation or health checks. Others mentioned listening to their partners more closely, or re-examining power dynamics. One participant mentioned bringing this information to their charity funder.

6.2. Summary and implications

The workshop, in summary, pointed towards a few implications of this research for the Wales-Africa community. Organisations are generally interested in, and see the value in, developing more balanced, reciprocal, and equal relationships – but they would benefit from greater support. This might include in:

- Delivering parallel projects (e.g. identifying areas to work on with their partner, bringing Welsh organisations on board that work in similar thematic areas as their partners in Africa)
- Recruiting volunteers; or having support in communicating their priorities and values to potential volunteers
- Embedding partnerships in the organisation (e.g. getting buy-in from senior executives)
- Clear and useful guidance on partnership health checks, evaluations, and examination of power dynamics
- Influencing the funding landscape to continue re-orienting itself towards longer-term and friendship-based approaches

These areas may provide some scope for collaboration between Dolen, Hub Cymru Africa, and other members of the Wales-Africa community to develop support for organisations working in partnership.

7. Limitations

It must be acknowledged that this research has been necessarily limited by time, and only a small subset of partnerships and participants have been consulted. Therefore any report will be, in effect, a snapshot – which is only one out of many possible.

Of the data that have been analysed, it is possible that these may be affected by "exceptional case bias" which can be either positive or negative – for example, participants in education partnerships are mainly from schools that have highly active partnerships; there may be other school partnerships that are moribund, and the less-enthusiastic participants would not have been identified to take part in research.

With all research participants, I introduced myself as a researcher who was not affiliated with either Dolen (or any of its member organisations), or the Welsh Government – but that my research was being funded by the Welsh Government. It is possible that some participants may have tried to make things "look better" if they felt it might impact their programme or its funding in future.

8. Summary

Research question 1 asks, "Does the Dolen model contribute to equal and effective partnership working? If so, how? And can these contributing factors be built on further?" My research indicates quite strongly that the answer to the first part is yes.

To answer the question "how?" a number of avenues have emerged, as described above. These four strands which I have identified are all inter-related, and each contributes to the others.

Focusing on a friendship- or solidarity-based partnership builds trust and commitment within the relationship. This in turn leads to more equal and effective work. For example, by building trust, Welsh organisations can move away from a "risk avoidance" approach to partnership working, which in itself entrenches inequality as the organisation in Lesotho is then forced to assume a greater share of risk. A position of more trust and commitment allows a longer-term and more holistic view of any initiatives, which improves effectiveness.

Prioritising reciprocal or balanced relationships (where each partner is working towards a shared goal in their own context, in addition to any initiatives carried out through the partnership; and where any exchanges or visits are also reciprocal) improves buy-in and ownership of the partnership work from each side, and increases motivation for participants on the work they do locally.

Embedding partnerships and making them part of and organisation's identity also contributes to equality and effectiveness by facilitating easier participation, shoring up the durability of the partnership and reducing its vulnerability especially to staff turnover, increasing buy-in from members or employees of the organisation, and extending benefits of the partnership even to those who are not direct participants themselves.

Finally, regular self-evaluation and examination of partnership dynamics supports greater effectiveness and equality by allowing partners to examine unconscious assumptions, automatic habits, or unhelpful

approaches which may have been brought to the partnership or developed over time. Checking in regularly on whether decision-making has been shared, resources allocated fairly, and communication made clearly and unambiguously, is a major contributor to progress in both effectiveness and equality.

With regards to what implication these findings have for the wider Wales Africa community, they track with community experience fairly closely. It appears that for community members, the challenge is in implementation. This may include overcoming inertia, ingrained habits, unconscious assumptions, or existing structures in their organisation; it may be getting more people (e.g. volunteers) on board or broadening their visions of what could be done; or it may be advocating for changes to funding structures or requirements from donors, or communicating more clearly to funders the importance of long-term relationships and holistic views, as indeed one participant narrated to me.

What remains to be done going forward will be for Dolen, its staff, volunteers, board, members, and partners, to address the question: What implication does this have for us, for what we do and how we do it? To that end I have prepared a reflection guide [link]. It is my hope that these materials will be useful and able to spark ongoing discussions that guide progress towards greater equality and effectiveness in partnerships, towards deeper friendships, towards furthering collaboration and cooperation between Wales and Lesotho and in the Wales-Africa community, and towards greater global solidarity.